

managed to handle the resulting complications better than he did."

Carlsen also weighed in on the much-anticipated clash between D. Gukesh and reigning World Champion Ding Liren.

"Based on current form, Gukesh is a significant favourite. But based on peak chess ability, I think it's quite even. So if Ding can regain that form, he has a good chance. Also, Gukesh was quite vulnerable in the last tournament that he played. But all that aside, if I were to make a prediction at this point, I'd go with the guy who's played by far the best chess of these two players over the last couple of years, which is Gukesh," he said.

However, he didn't rule out Ding's chances of retaining his title. "Each World Championship has its own

rhythm. It's something he hasn't experienced before, so I think he might take some time getting into it. Ding probably justifiably feels that he's the underdog, so maybe he doesn't have that much to lose. Overall, it's not a foregone conclusion. I believe that some people think this match is almost a formality at this point, but I think there is more than a 50 per cent chance that this match is quite even."

Carlsen also reaffirmed his disinterest in returning to the World Championship cycle, regardless of who holds the title. "A long-form classical match doesn't interest me against anybody. Whoever wins the Championship, it will be tremendous, but it's not something I'll seek to challenge," he said.

Addressing criticism from Garry



Final Standings – Open

Rapid

Magnus Carlsen (7.5); R. Praggnanandhaa (5.5); Wesley So (5.5); Nodirbek Abdusattorov (5); Vincent Keymer (4.5); Nihal Sarin (4); Daniil Dubov (3.5); Arjun Erigaisi (3.5); Vidit Gujrathi (3); S. L. Narayanan (3).

Blitz

Magnus Carlsen (13); Wesley So (11.5); Arjun Erigaisi (10.5); R. Praggnanandhaa (9.5); Vidit Gujrathi (9); Daniil Dubov (9); Nodirbek Abdusattorov (8); Nihal Sarin (7); S.L. Narayanan (6.5); Vincent Keymer (6).

